

Lessons

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Adding and Subtracting Number... ▾

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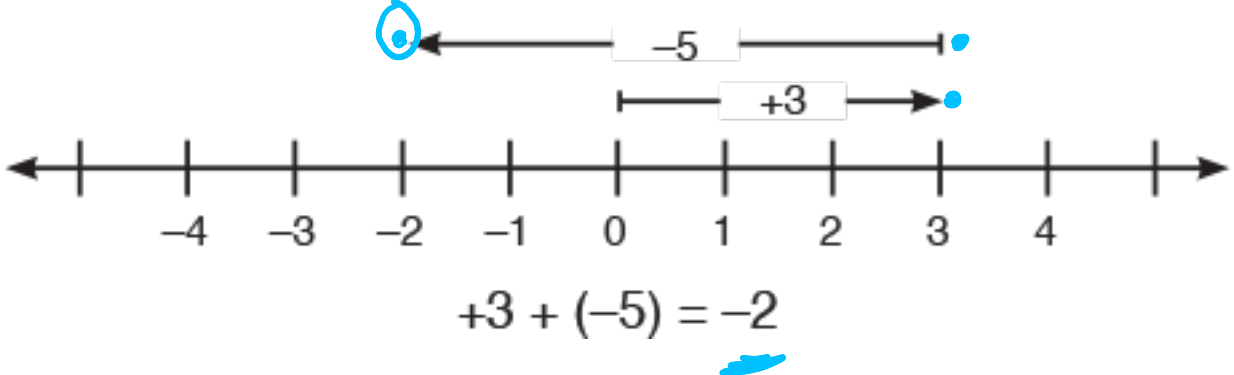
Adding and Subtracting Numbers with Signs

Toolbox

Adding and Subtracting Numbers with Signs

Adding signed numbers is like walking on a number line. Positive distances are to the right, and negative distances are to the left.

The number line shows what happens when you add $+3$ and -5 . Starting at 0, go 3 steps to the right. To add -5 , go 5 steps to the left.



What would happen if you took 1 step forward and then 1 step back? You would be right back where you started. In other words, $+1$ plus -1 is 0.

$+ + - = 0$

In the examples below, positive and negative counters are used to model addition.

Example 1

[Hide](#)

$(+2) + (+3) = +5$ $+ + + + + = +5$

Example 2

[Hide](#)

$(-4) + (-2) = -6$ $- - - - + - - = -6$

These examples add positive *and* negative numbers.

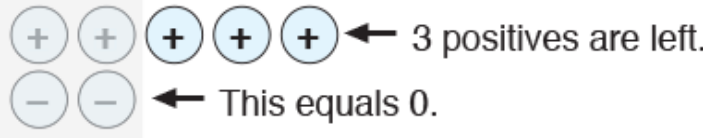
Example 3

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These examples add positive *and* negative numbers.

$(+5) + (-2) = +3$

Draw 5 positive circles and 2 negative circles. Since $+2$ plus -2 $= 0$, there are 3 positives left.

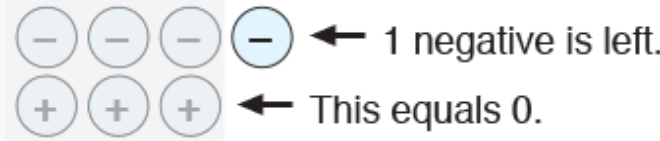


Example 4

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$(-4) + (+3) = -1$

Draw 4 negative circles and 3 positive circles. Since -3 plus $+3 = 0$, there is 1 negative left.



There are rules for adding signed numbers. Make sure you understand how the rules in the box relate to the examples. Good test takers do more than memorize rules. They try to visualize what the rules are saying.

Rules for Adding Signed Numbers

- 1 If the signs are the same, add the numbers and keep the same sign.
- 2 If the signs are different, subtract the numbers (without their signs). Think about the circles. Keep the sign that would have more circles.

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Category

Lesson 2: Operations with Whole Numbers and Decimals

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